

APM Project Management Qualification

Learner Study Pack



Assurance

Introduction

This section of the Learner Study Pack will cover the Assurance competence of the APM Project Management Qualification.

This section will enable you to gain an understanding of assurance as the process of providing confidence to stakeholders that projects, programmes and portfolios will achieve their objectives for beneficial change.

Learning objective and outcomes

Learning objective:

7. Understand assurance as the ability to provide confidence to the governance board that a project is on track to deliver objectives.

By the end of this activity, you should be able to:

7a) Know the purpose of assurance within a project; including awareness of the scope, priorities and strategic aims of assurance activities.

Study time

This section of the Learner Study Pack will take approximately 1 - 2 hours to complete.

Recommended resources

In addition to your Learner Study Pack, use the below references for more information on Assurance:

- APM Body of Knowledge Seventh edition 1.3.2 (Assurance principles)
- APM (2012) Project Reviews, Assurance and the PMO <https://www.apm.org.uk/blog/project-reviews-assurance-and-the-pmo/>
- APM (2019) What is the value of assurance? <https://www.apm.org.uk/blog/what-is-the-value-of-assurance/>

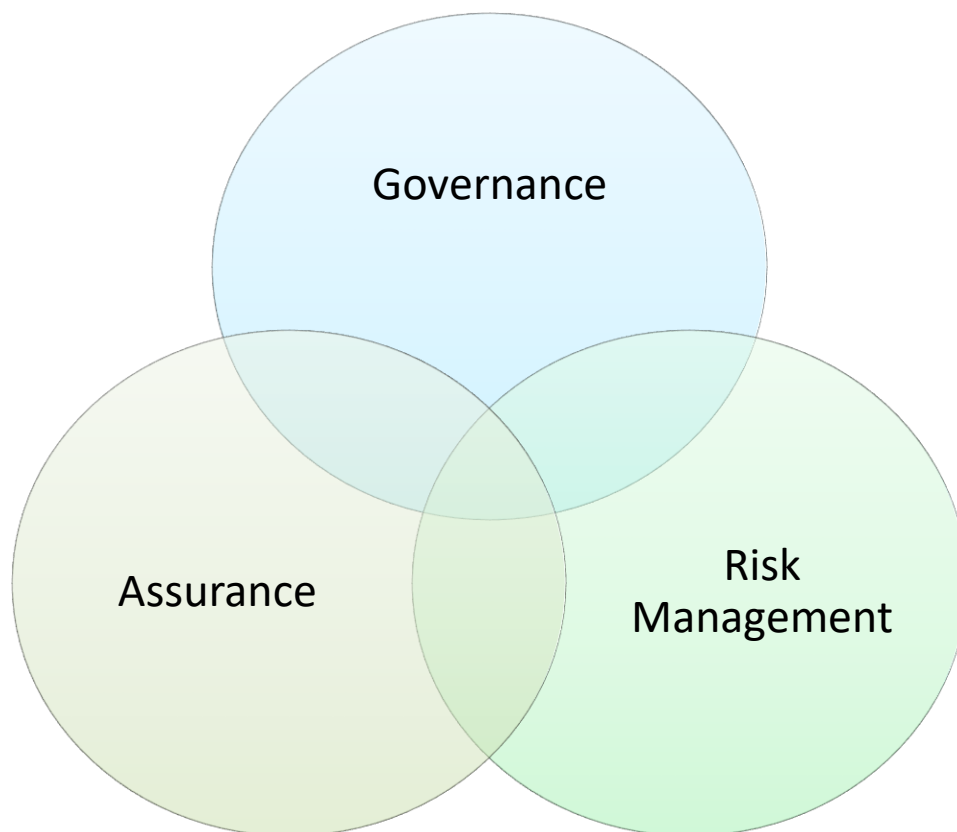
Overview

Assurance within a project is an objective and independent approach that has been agreed by the Project Sponsor and other key stakeholders.

It provides:

- Confidence to the governance board that the project is on track.
- Support to the decision making and change control processes.
- Improved accuracy of risk assessment.
- Increased probability of projects meeting their primary objectives.

Assurance must go hand in hand with Governance and Risk Management as any weakness in one of these three areas will negatively affect the others, as well as the project overall.



Assurance activities

Examples of valuable Assurance activities may include:

- Controls

This could be the application of a management system which is made up of policies, procedures, processes, and agreed standards.

These controls are intended to control and minimise the impact of risks.

- Compliance

This could include monitoring, regular checks and audits by risk management, quality assurance and even Project Management Office (PMOs).

These compliance measures are intended to confirm the control of risks.

- Independent Review

These could include independent reviews by internal audit, external audit (e.g. National Audit Office NAO), independent peers or external scrutiny.

These reviews are intended to provide a strategic overview of the systems of control.

Assurance Plan

To be successful, an assurance plan must meet the following criteria:

1. It must be independent, objective and proportionate to the work.
2. It must target the greatest risks.
3. It must show clear accountabilities for all assurance arrangements, activities and subsequent outputs
4. It must show that timings of cycles of assurance activities are planned and coordinated.
5. It must show a clear governance route for reporting outcomes and resolving issues.

Scenario One:

Everyone wants to make sure that the renovation project runs smoothly, especially Robin the Finance Manager. They are incredibly thorough, fastidious, and practical – they've seen projects of this scale flounder before, and they want to ensure that this doesn't happen at Snappy Appy.

They're concerned that this project could potentially mean even more work for their team, that is already stretched working on other projects and knows how easily things can be missed or overlooked.

As this is the first time that Snappy Appy has made such a large investment in its own growth, they are also very keen to see that clear 'checks and balances' are introduced to ensure their confidence.

What are some of the potential risks involved in this project and what processes or procedures could you introduce to mitigate those risks?

What assurance measures could be introduced to ensure that any decisions made during the project support its strategic direction?

Scenario Two

Both Ayo, the Founder/CEO and Robin are concerned that a project of this size and with this many people involved could quickly descend into 'he said/she said'.

They both have a lot to gain from the project being successful and a lot to lose from its failure. They want to give everyone involved the space and the freedom to do their best work, but they also want to ensure that they know what is happening with the project and when.

Robin is particularly interested in keeping oversight of the project as they know that the investors will be following progress closely to ensure that budget limitations are not exceeded, and deadlines missed.

What suggestions could you make to ensure that all major stakeholders are kept informed and engaged for the duration of the project?

Scenario Three

Sandeep the Head of Development has come to you as they are feeling the pressure already of the project – they must juggle their normal workload, keep their team motivated and energised throughout the imminent changes, and ensure that they are assisting in any way possible.

They also don't want to let Ayo down as they created the company's very first app together and they feel an incredible sense of obligation and loyalty towards their Founder/CEO and friend!

As an experienced Project Manager, Sandeep is looking to you to give guidance on the creation and implementation of an assurance plan that will enable them to focus on their team while knowing that all the accountabilities and outputs are under control.

What steps and/or criteria would you include in the assurance plan to put Sandeep's mind at ease?

Scenario Four

Robin has been nominated to undertake assurance reviews at various stages throughout the duration of the renovation project.

However, they are very interested in ensuring that the project and its processes are in line with the IT development industry's best practices. As a result, they would like to have independent reviews completed externally as well as the internal reviews.

What external review recommendations could you make to Robin to ensure that the company is adopting corporate best practice?

Learning review questions

Before you attempt the exam practice questions in the next section, we recommend you review your learning to quickly see which aspects you don't understand or can't remember as well.

It will also boost your confidence by confirming what you have learnt and your demonstrated ability to apply that knowledge, so that you are ready to practise for the exam.

Here are some questions you may wish to answer to review your learning from the Assurance section:

- Which specific assurance reviews play a key role in stakeholder engagement and why?
- What is the link between undertaking robust and regular assurance reviews and the effectiveness of decision making on a project? Why do they have such a significant impact?

Exam practice questions

7.1 Regarding project assurance, which two statements are true?

(1 mark)

1. Assurance is not needed if an organisation has specialist risk managers.
2. Assurance is unnecessary in low-cost projects.
3. Assurance ensures day-to-day project activities are carried out effectively..
4. Assurance gives stakeholders confidence that the project will deliver its aims.
5. Assurance should be carried out at multiple points through the project lifecycle.
6. Assurance is always conducted by someone external to the organisation.

Select the correct combination of two statements:

- a. 1 & 3
- b. 2 & 6
- c. 4 & 5
- d. 1 & 6

7.2

What are four benefits of carrying out assurance activities and one reason why you might choose to have assurance carried out by an external company?

(5 marks)

Exam practice answers

Question	Answer / Mark scheme
7.1	C
7.2	1 mark for each of the benefits below – 4 marks available in total. For example, but not limited to: • It gives an objective view of how the project is performing. • It can give reassurance / confidence to stakeholders that the project is performing / on track. • It can support effective decision making. • It can make sure that change control / risk management / quality management / (other project governance activities) are being carried out appropriately. • It increases the probability of a project being successful / meeting its objectives. 1 mark for a reason why you might choose to have assurance carried out by an external company. For example, but not limited to: • To make sure that the assurance is fully independent / not influenced by the project team / not influenced by organisational concerns.